

World-Integration Series:



# Thoreau Gandhi Vinoba

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by  
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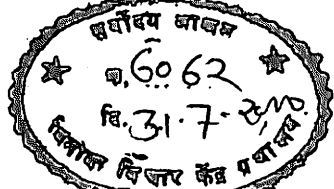
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## Foreword



To today's thinking American, and I suspect, non-American as well, Henry David Thoreau stands for the best that thinking America came up with during the eruptive years before the tragic Civil War. The fight over slavery and the failure of the great conflict to release the Negro from economic, political and social enslavement (though his legal status changed) are perhaps America's darkest national memories. But ironically, the years of debate which Thoreau called "the great moral earthquake" before the Civil War, also brought out the best that the nation has yet produced. For it was then that Thoreau, Emerson, Lincoln and scores of other thinkers, poets and politicians developed for posterity concepts of The Higher Law of Conscience in a modern expression. Their conclusions (and actions) have influenced India's own history, as they are influencing the American Negro's actions at the present time.

It is this "Higher Law of Conscience" which Mr. Reddy's discussion of Thoreau focuses on. The value of the chapters that follow is in the insights they give us into what Thoreau calls "action from principle, the perception and performance of right." Thoreau's own life, on a smaller scale, often parallels Gandhi's grander efforts in that both "experimented" day by day with the "truths" they perceived. Few of us can claim this kind of courage because few of us have cared so much.

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## THOREAU

*This Article is an attempt to explore the hidden treasures of one of America's neglected authors who lived for himself yet, he moved the world for a considerable period with his simple sylvian qualities. No sane person could have thought that Thoreau's paper on 'Civil Disobedience' would be considered one day as a turning point in the history of American liberal thought. However, 'Civil Disobedience' served as a text-book for Mahatma Gandhi in the recent years in South Africa and subsequently became a 'Manual of Arms' for all reformers throughout the World.*

In this world are born from generation to generation some rare men of thought and action like Thoreau. Thoreau is one of America's most neglected authors of mid-nineteenth Century as Pasternak is one of Russia's most neglected authors in the recent past. Although Thoreau may not be called as the architect of American Nation as much as George Washington and Abraham Lincoln, but he can be rightly considered as the arch-angel of American democracy and a pioneer of free liberal thought which however dominated the latter part of the 19th and the early part of the 20th century American Ideology in one or the other way.

Thoreau was a blend of both sylvian and human qualities. So, we find in him the ideal synthesis of Liberalism and Altruism. If we make a careful study of Rousseau, Tolstoy, Wordsworth, Diogenes and Aristophanes and compare their essential trends with Thereau, we discover more resemblances than differences.

Jean Jacques Rousseau was a son of a watch-maker. Rousseau wrote a novel 'La Nouvelle Heloise' which discussed the theme 'Return to Nature'. Henry David Thoreau was the son of pencil manufacturer who wrote a book 'Walden' or 'Life in the Woods' which reflected love of Nature. Rousseau led a wretched erratic life of which he admits in his 'Confessions'. On the other hand Thoreau led an isolated life on the edge of the Walden Pond. Rousseau's original thought is reflected through his 'Social Contract'. The influence of 'Social Contract' was so deep that it soon resulted in French Revolution. On the other hand 'Civil Disobedience' marks the original contribution of Thoreau which later on resulted in a Civil War, the struggle of Negroes for civil rights in the American South.

Count Leo Tolstoy a 19th century Russian writer whose conclusions involved Non-resistance to evil, the Abolition of Governments and Nationalities of Churches aimed at a strong belief in love of men and faith in God. On the other side, Thoreau who carried on his Civil resistance, Anti-slavery and Reform campaigns against the 'Starch-Shirt-Collars' throughout his life in America was passionately devoted to Woods and Nature. Thus Tolstoy's intuitive Realism and Thoreau's transcendental Idealism approximate with one another in their essential approaches.

William Wordsworth, the leader of the Romantic Revival conducted a walking tour to Alps and published some descriptive sketches of Alps through his First series of Poetical works. He set-out on a tour of Scotland and published his 'Excursions' in 1814. Apart from this, his 'Memorials of a tour on the Continent' is a collection of poems appeared in 1822. On the other hand Thoreau who belonged to one-member Concord Group of writers conducted several tours in his life-time which is evident through his various publications like 'A Winter Walk', 'A Walk to Wachusett', 'Excursion' and 'Early Spring in Massachusetts' etc. However, Wordsworth is remembered as the father of Romanticism whereas Thoreau is considered as the child of Transcendentalism.

Diogenes the Greek philosopher who was born in 4th century B. C., in the above-normal heights of austerity preferred to live finally in a large Earthen Jar. It is said that when Alexander, the Roman General, asked Diogenes whether he could oblige him in any way; the latter replied 'yes! by standing out of my sunshine'. This reply left an indelible influence on Alexander who said to himself that 'if I were not Alexander I should wish to be Diogenes'. Thoreau the 19th century transcendental Naturalist was also an ascetic but his asceticism was counterpoised by his over-rebellious nature. Thoreau withdrew from society and built for himself a solitary Cabin on the shores of the Walden Pond. It is stated that the distance of the Cabin from Concord was not more than 1 1/2 miles. Thoreau being a self-made man borrowed an Axe and constructed the Cabin by himself and he moved into it on Independence Day. Thoreau's life of Isolation is unique which is filled with rich experience. Although bathed in Walden Pond, worked on Walden Farm and wandered through Concord Woods he lived amidst the world of Nature, reflected its message to the people who lived outside Nature.

Aristophanes an Athenian Comic poet who lived in 4th century B. C. was known for his Comedies and Carricatures of the leading personages of the time and their comments on current affairs. He wrote 'The Clouds' a criticism of the new spirit of Philosophical enquiry which in his opinion was devoid of content. Likewise, Thoreau the Concord Poet of Nature in his caricatures of the age of growing industry criticised the American Government for its decline in the real sense. His first poem 'Sympathy' which was later published in the 'Dial' holds an Irony about American life.

Henry David Thoreau was born on July 12 1817 in Concord Massachusetts. He hails from an heterogenous ancestry mostly of French descent, Thoreau was the third of the four children born to his father, a pencil manufacturer by profession. Helen

his first sister was older to him by 5 years and a brother John 2 years elder to him who died of Lock-jaw and Sophia was his second sister much younger to him. Cynthia his mother loved him much next to Sophia. Thoreau born as he was in a hard working family could study with utmost care and he was soon graduated from Harvard in 1837. After 4 years of his graduation he came in contact with Emerson the then established writer in whose association Thoreau was very much inspired to think and write, react and rebel. Besides, Emerson, among the most influential friends of Thoreau, come Alcott who wrote high about him in his biography of Thoreau. Alcott was originally an associate of Emerson but he was fascinated more towards the burning zeal of Thoreau. Alcott compares the rude social complexities of societies with the substantial solitude of Thoreau and says that the latter's life was full of meaning.

‘ Societies. were all but rude  
In his unbrageous Solitude. ’

Thoreau's Contributions include Books, Essays, Poems, Papers, Letters and his Impressions and Reflections. 'The Seasons' his earliest known essay was published as early as in 1827. 'Excursion', the 'Cape Cod', and the 'Maine Woods' were his later contributions. Among his other know minor writings are, 'Summer' and 'Autumn', 'Land lord' and 'Service', 'Chastity and Sensuality'. 'Early Spring in Massachusetts' which is more a Natural history of Massachusetts, indicates a life everlasting in pastures and readily pleads for a life which is more penetrating and restorative. There is also an irony embeded in this particular publication about the then existing social rigorism. Thoreau feels that the present society has lost all its vigorous qualities of human and social affection. With it man has lost his Manliness. Nothing remained in the society except the worn-out laws

‘ Society-there is no scent in it  
so wholesome as that of the pines ’.

His 'Chastity and Sensuality' is an irony of Western culture as much as Oswald Spengler's. 'Decline of the West' is a bitter criticism of the West. His 'Herald of Freedom' is a revolt against Industry on one hand and the re-affirmation of faith in man & his means on the other-which in many respects resembles the 'Rights of Man' written by Thomas Paine the spirited writer of the 19th century. His 'Friendship' which explores an etherial type of love and Idealistic human relations can very well be compared with the most original ideas of Aristotle's 'Friendship'. Above all, 'A Week on the Concord and Merrimack River' is filled with transcendental optimism of man. The human intuition and social conscience seemed to have been so synthesised in this work that it later on became a Bible for all lovers of Nature for more than a decade. This trend of Thoreau's spontaneous disposition can be studied in the light of Schweitzers' life and world-affirmation. 'Walden' or Life in the Woods the other significant book of Thoreau which aims more at individual reformation than social evolution was published in 1854 after 27 years of his literary career. The maturity of thought seems to have predominated over his impulsive feeling particularly in this work. Thoreau's love of Nature is significantly manifested in this publication. Speaking of Individual Reform, Thoreau tends to say.

'It will avail little unless we are ourselves  
essentially noble enough to inspire those  
whom we would so benefit with nobleness.'

Justifying his stand on the stay at Walden, Thoreau emphatically compares the common material standards of human existence with the rare substantial eternities of life in this way:

'I was rich, if not in money  
in sunny hours and summer days'

Thoreau, writing on the possibility of progress of human life says that human life is instantaneous in its evolution. We cannot predict as when it grows, as much as we cannot predict the growth of a tree and the floods of a river. It is by sudden conver-

sion man enlightens and purifies himself. These lines very well indicate his transcendental optimism.

‘The life in us, is like the water in the river.  
It may rise this year, higher than man has  
ever known it, and flood the parched uplands.’

Thoreau’s ‘Familiar Letters’ soon became very popular. particularly his ‘Letters to various persons’ edited by Emerson in the year 1865 received popular approbation This is a clear indication of the working of a higher mind through them.

Thoreau’s Poetical publications moved the mid-nineteenth century for a decade to follow. ‘Sympathy’ was the first known poem of the rebel-poet which appeared in the ‘Dial’ and the ‘Poems of Nature’ a collection of Verse edited by Carl Bode appeared in 1943. Among the few poetical writings very few were qualitative which received admiration. The deep natural love of Thoreau never spared even his poetical publications. According to Thoreau poets and poetry are merely the phases of Second Nature and they cannot at any time take the place of Real Nature. Nature will provide us with the first hand information about things through its direct communion with man. When man establishes a *rappor*t with Nature he need not seek for any other medium whatsoever as was the case with the poet himself.

‘Tell Shakespeare to attend some leisure hour  
For now I have business with the drop of dew.’

On some other occasions the Concord poet of Nature becomes extremely sensitive about the objects of Nature around him and at every movement he feels for them. His deeper feeling pulsates with the changes in the surrounding phenomena. He is ever sensitive to the fast fading objects of Nature and feels that he is robbed of their kindered association.

‘And the rustling of the withered leaf  
Is the constant music of my grief.’



Thoreau drawing a line of demarcation between the two opposing equiforms of human experience Precept and Practice and their actual realisation in ones' life says that these two values are always contradictory and never complementary to one another on any occasion. If a man is all-out to preach some noetic ideals he can never practice them by himself in the real sense. Again similarly, if a man is wholly engrossed in the practice of the same he fails to interpret them through his thought. So, for this reason great men of thought never attained to become great men of action and the great men of action were never great men of thought. In his autobiographical tone the poet brings himself into this reality-picture and says that he could have been called great if he have had attempted to theorise his little achievements in his life but he was afraid of his own progress on the path of action – lest he may be left with the little time at his command.

My life hath been the poem I would write.  
But I could not both live and let live to utter it."

The rebellious spirit of Thoreau pleaded for extreme individualism. A man who follows the promptings of his own heart and the dictates of his own conscience is self-governed, and he who is self-governed is governed by none except himself. No tyrant can rule such a man who is self-ruled and obedient to one's own sense of goodness.

'He's governed well who rules himself  
.....No despot vetoes him.'

Thoreau's campaign against slavery lead to many movements as Anti-slavery and Reform In Concord Society. Thoreau himself published noted papers on anti-slavery and Civil disobedience in 1849. Better die rather than share dishonour was the main dictum of the spirited soul. Slavery is no less than a social mockery. It is indeed a degradation of the values of human existence. Thoreau's whole life is a life of struggle to overthrow servitude. Authority and slavery according to him are man-made moulds so man alone can extirpate them.

Thoreau's eccentricities are more than his whimsicalities. His extreme individualism impelled him to indulge in many a mental conjecture which however resulted in his atypical singularity behaviours on many an occasion. His rebelliousness which dominated his life in innumerable ways blazed his temperament to revolt radically against the existing authority and self-centred autocracy of the age. Even in his early years he refused to pay five dollars to Harvard and as a result he never received his College diploma. Thoreau considered the above diploma as 'superfluous and semi-fraudulent'. Thoreau's zeal for service forced him to work at Concord school for some time but when one of the members of the school committee attempted to persuade him to punish his pupils as a measure of discipline he was compelled to submit his resignation on the spot picking-up a quarrel with the authority.

Thoreau was however arrested for his mutinous activities and re-calcitrant behaviour when he constantly resisted the Government and defied to pay the poll-tax in the year 1846. He was in Concord jail for a night as a consequence of his defiance of the law. He wanted that none should pay the poll tax for him as a matter of principle. Although many of his friends and associates were ready to remit the amount in the nearest office but they were extremely afraid of the fiery nature of Thoreau. Some how his old aunt managed to pay the tax of her own accord and got him released. There is a legend which goes that when Emerson visited Thoreau when the latter was in jail and asked him 'why are you here?' Thoreau retorted and said 'why are you not here?'

No sane man could have thought that Thoreau's paper on Civil Disobedience would be treated one day as an important milestone in America's achievement towards free liberal thought particularly when Brason Alcott refused to publish it in his paper 'Dial'. Although civil disobedience had a theme which was at once universal, many men of the age of Thoreau fail to realise its un-

limited scope. However, Civil Disobedience can be considered invariably as a re-affirmation of Thoreau's defiant disposition and characteristic individualism. In the succeeding centuries that followed Thoreau's Resistance, Civil Disobedience became a Manual of Arms for all political and social reformers throughout the world. For many years this book served as a text-book for Mahatma Gandhi in South Africa, a Bible for British Labour Party in England and as an important weapon for the resistance movement under Nazi occupation in Europe in 1940 and quite recently the spirit of Civil Disobedience is being utilized by Negroes in their struggle for civil rights in the American South. However, the main theme of Civil Disobedience was also recognised in Paine and Jefferson who together said that 'Government is best which governs least'. According to Walter Hording Thoreau's chief purpose in writing Civil Disobedience was to

'wean men away from their adherence to an insidious relativism.'

Thus, the purpose of Civil Disobedience never stops with this passive resistance but it rolls further ahead towards rational persuasion of the people to come back to their own original superior standards of human truth.

One of the most popular themes of Thoreau's Civil Disobedience is that of reformation, then revolution. The reform of the individual will invariably lead to the reform of the society. If the individuals are unprepared to evolve by themselves a higher consciousness in life, the social reform programme cannot be worked out, however, through social action. Social action may facilitate individual evolution but cannot be the cause of personal conversion. Thoreau even pleaded for the destruction of such of those social institutions which tend to corrupt the individuality and spontaneity of man in his 'Civil Disobedience'. Thoreau's views on disarmament are unique and at once awe-inspiring to any liberal democracy. On one occasion he says that

'standing army is only an arm of the standing government.'

In Thoreau's opinion the majority becomes meaningless when judged merely from the point of view of numbers. The law of the land may however stand supreme over all other ordinary laws. But the moral law is Imperative which is to be followed strictly, willingly and conscientiously. On the basis of expediency men are prone to law more than their Rights. This characteristic attribute of Nations is really detestable and deplorable in the words of Thoreau. Thus his Civil Disobedience is more an assertion of rights than the realisation of duties.

'It is not desirable to cultivate a respect  
for the law so much as for the right.'

Thoreau's individualism indicates a high sense of self-respect for man and his pursuits. Loyalty to the Nation never means subjugation of one's self and an insubordination of one's rights to the State, provided the good sense of man should prevail. In his 'Civil Disobedience' Thoreau made a remark on the above lines :

'We should be men first and subjects afterwards.'

The fundamental freedom of thought, proper choice of moral alternatives and an ideal lay-out of the life-plan should be taught well to the citizens in order to make them complete and wholesome men. Against such a broad context of human ideal, the natural freedom of the individual citizen, will become an imperative need. If proper environmental conditions are not provided to a plant according to its native needs it ceases to flourish; on the other hand it will soon perish and meet a natural death. So, a man who is by nature deprived of his basic freedom, ceases to exist both morally and spiritually. With such a creative note Thoreau concludes the first part of his 'Civil Disobedience'.

If a plant cannot live according to its nature,  
it dies, and so a man

According to Thoreau ;

'A Corporation has no conscience but a  
Corporation of conscientious men is a  
Corporation with a conscience.'

This indicates that man who tends to form the base of the great hierarchy of democracies throughout the world is concerned much and such a man can alone be the creative author of an Ideal State.

Thoreau never believes in the nature of Polling practiced in modern democracies. Polling had lately become an unhealthy sport of the political parties. All voting is a sort of gaming according to Thoreau.

In the recent past there has been many a trend of thought in India as regards the real nature of service to the Nation. Whether a man in-Office can serve his Nation best or a man who is without any position or Office. Thoreau shares his views with Indians in this respect. He is of the opinion that

'if you really wish to do any thing  
resign your Office.'

On one hand Thoreau regarded no-Authority to rule and on the other hand, he disregarded the government by representation. In his opinion 'right' was not a mass question but it is each man's native concern. There is no virtue in mass government. It is only the collective of mass which impels the establishment of a mass government if it really exists at all. On the other hand there is force in each man's moral decision which is more a matter of intuition than election which has indeed given a proper lead to the Nations of the world.

Thoreau's views on taxation are unique. Taxation without representation was a tyranny with almost all the liberal thinkers of America. In 'Civil Disobedience' Thoreau emphatically admitted his denial to pay the Poll-Tax but he gloriously confesses that he paid all other taxes, which in his opinion were modest and just. In ancient Indian polity the policy of taxation was based upon the principles of equity, productivity and capacity of the people to pay. On this basis there was a great harmony and understanding between the Tax-Payers and the Tax-Gatherers,

Panchatantra illustrates several examples to explain this happy blend. A Gardner collects the flowers of the garden without harming the plants; a Bee sucks the honey from the pollen without causing injury to the flowers; and the Milkman milks the cow leaving some milk for the calf. There is much to be learnt from the above traditional truths of every day experience. Similarly if the government of the land sensitively wishes its inhabitants welfare, justly collects the taxes, there will not be any friction between the two. In the long run both are mutually benefitted. Panchatantra explains this fact by a simple example. A person who kills the goat can at best get one sumptuous meal but one who brings up the goat carefully, can get its milk for a number of years. Thus Thoreau's views on taxation are self-benefitting and far-fetching from both physical and metaphysical aspects of ideal Polity.

No one among the Concord Circle predicted that Thoreau the recluse of Concord would one day become a Philosopher of high recognition. Thoreau was never a philosopher in the real academic sense as Spencer and Spinoza, Kant, and Hegel. In one way he can be called as a philosopher of life. Thoreau resembles to a great extent with some of the moral and romantic philosophers of Nature. His solitary contemplation of Nature, his full belief in Intuition, and his implicit faith in the intrinsic Nature of the individual, all imply that he was out-and-out a transcendentalist. His belief in the existence of the over-soul and his faith in the communion with the Absolute all go to prove that Thoreau was an absolute Idealist of high order. His all-inclusive love of life and etherial belief in the Hegelian spirit further indicate his super-eminent virtues. Thoreau ordinarily can be compared with the Fox-Trio, i. e., with George Fox, a moral liberal of the 16th century, John Fox, the 19th century American novelist who wrote on the 'Life of the Mountain Folk' and also with the John Fox, the 15th century martyrologist who wrote a 'Book of Martyrs'—as all of them had a deep 'quest for life' in their own lives. Thoreau's 'free-will' was never airy; on the other

hand it gave birth to a most positive trend of thought i.e., 'Will-to-Live'. Thoreau's transcendental philosophy can very well be illustrated by his own ecstatic expression as:

'Once I lost a grey Hound, a bay Horse and a turtle Dove, and searching the same I met many a man on my way, but most of them were alien to what has all happened, but of the few who knew my losses were also after them.'

This mystic expression is indeed considered as one of the most significant aspects of his transcendental thought which provoked even many of his contemporaries to seek after a richer life and to run after nobler ideals. Thoreau like Wordsworth loved his boyhood through nature. He never loved child as the Father of man but he loved him as the Child of Nature. William Wordsworth reviews in his reminiscences the glories of his childhood in orchard, in meadow and in wild-woods and feels sorry at his present losses. Thoreau compares his present mechanical life of manhood with the etherial life of his childhood and says that he could not repair the irreparable loss at any cost.

'No experience which I have today is comparable with the experience of my boyhood..... my life was ecstasy.'

The ecstatic life of his transparent childhood can not be recalled through the thick layers of his present mechanical life. Thoreau believed in 'Chance variations' of life. Though creative synthesis was the law of his life, yet he was a parcel of vain strivings:

'I am a parcel of vain strivings tied by a chance bond together.'

Walt Whitman, the 19th century poet who wrote many poems in an unconventional manner, in his 'song of myself' expresses his deep desire to live with animals. According to him the animals are placid and self-contained within their little existences. Thoreau sees no nonsense in animal existence and so he is attrac-

ted towards them as much as he is drifted towards natural vegetation.

'I do not consider other animals brutes in the common sense. I am attracted towards them undoubtedly because I never heard any nonsense from them.'

Thoreau established a complete *rappor*t with Nature particularly when he lived at the banks of Walden Pond. He used to sit some times at the edge of his little door of the self-made Cabin till the sun descends slightly to the west and at some other times he used to watch flowers blossom fully for hours together sitting at their stems and on some other occasions he conducted a wild-walk through the wild Pines counting their thick and thin trunks. Giving the autobiographical sketch of his Wanderings in Walden he reviews his remniscences and says that :

'I spent a couple of years with the flowers chiefly having none other so binding engagement as to observe when they opened'

Thoreau expressed his resentment towards the journals of his age which reflected no realities. Therefore he recommended people to read not the Times but the Eternities. There can be the other significance of the expression i. e. Thoreau might have asked people to rightly distinguish between perceptual time or 'duration' and the conceptual time or 'Eternity'. Thoreau might have hinted at the eternal Time which tends to transcend both perceptual and conceptual dimensions. Pragmatic ideals of science teach us to doubt and to be ignorant of the real life. Alexander Pope, the son of a linen draper of London was known very soon as the great poet of Pastorals in the 17th century. England. Being influenced by his able friend Boling Broke her published a moral poem 'An Essay on Man'. This is a philosophical Irony upon science and scientists of the Age. Pope disparagingly says:



'Go and be guided by Science; teach others the eternal wisdom as how to rule; and in case if it is not possible of you, you then drop into thyself and be a Fool'.

In almost similar vein Thoreau criticises the futility of scientists to a civilized race any says that.

'Scientists are those plants growing in drak forests which put forth only leaves instead of blossoms'.

Thomas Jefferson in his 'Declaration of Independence' very well affirmed his views on Equality and said that all men are created equal with some inalienable rights as Life, Liberty and the Pursuit of Happiness. On the other hand Henry David Thoreau declared in his 'Civil Disobedience' that individuality, equality and liberty are the birth rights of all who are destined to be called men.

Love of money is the root of all evil says the New Testament. Money is not required to buy even one necessary of the soul said Thoreau. Oliver Goldsmith the 18th century sylvian poet and a world citizen wrote in his 'Deserted Village', "where wealth accumulates men decay" Thoreau the 19th century sylvian poet in his 'Walden' saidt hat superfluous wealth can buy superfluities only. An enlightened self-interest in any enterprise is however not bad but a better motive. That self-interest is high and sublime which involves the greatest good of all instead of the good of one individual. It is always heard that money is hard but it is yet more harder to know as how best to use money. Real wealth transcends money but money is devoid of real wealth. Money is the medium of mere exchange of commodities in these days. It has ceased to hold its original medium of value i. e., *Aishvaryam*. Money is however not a bad medium but it is indeed a bad source. The craze for money and the race for riches has deprived man of his real wealth—the wealth of values in these days. Science is progressively decreas-

ing the ignorance of the individuals but it is instantaneously increasing the darkness of the present race. Thus, we see the value of money is being discussed by all prophets from Thoreau to Gandhi. The very idea of money is itself an evil according to Thoreau. Money makes ugly all it touches.

Robert Green Ingersol who lived in the early part of the 19th century described progress as an inevitable phenomenon of human nature. Mere diffusion of knowledge and rarefaction of Ignorance is not progress. Again free-thought and liberal-spirit can not be considered as the sole mediums of progress. Progress, according to Ingersol, is an inward process, a law of life, it is both an involution of the Spirit and the evolution of the Matter. Progress has been written on every soul. It is the veneration, of existence. Despising the antiquity and admiring the up-to-date is not a progress. According to the remarkable rebel-philosopher of Walden-Thoreau, the reform of the outward life is not a progress. The ennobling enrichment of our whole nature is the real progress. The self-impelled laws of human existence are much more useful to man than the the governing laws of the legislatures. Thoreau like Erasmus, the great Dutch humanist who lived in the 15th century, interpreted human progress in terms of human evolution in relation to the intrinsic values of human existence. An inward zest for life and not the outward search for living has been the central core of thought with one and all men of progress. Human destiny and Human progress are inalienable concepts in human history. The need for future necessity of man's evolution, the logical out-come of his actuality from his future destiny, the idea of divine fore-ordainment in relation to the unalterable course of human events etc., were very well defined by many philosophers from Kant the transcendental philosopher of the 18th century down to Charles Peirce, the pragmatic philosopher of the modern period. Thoreau like many other self-inspired thinkers of the world finds life meaningful and purposeful and yet he says that man does not need to know its origin and destiny. Man's origin, purpose and destiny are worthier than any of the worthies. The noblest man is one

who never runs purposely after these worthies. They run away from those who run after them.

"The Unconscious of the man according to Thoreau is the Conscious of God."

Thoreau's teachings cover every aspect of life if carefully studied. Therefore, it becomes impossible on our part to explore every truth of his thought in our present criticism of his philosophy. The greatness of the great man is not often viewed in quantitative wholes but it is always discovered in qualitative parts. If we study Thoreau's contributions in the above order we are forced to include his name among the creative thinkers of a very high order. He was as great as some of the first rank thinkers who inalienably represented the East. Thoreau's emphasis on human nature brings him nearer to Menicus, his emphasis on social order is nearer to that of Motzus and his insistence on individual freedom resembles in all its aspects with the Taoist insistence on individual freedom. Again, Thoreau's transcendentalism draws him nearer to the Confucian mysticism. In short, Thoreau was an Integral Humanist as much as a Radical Reformist – ADIEU. ●

## GANDHI

*The object of this Article is to impress upon the readers the universality of Gandhian Ideology and its impact on day-to-day world problems.*

*Can Gandhian Ideology be called a Synthetic Ideology in the context of the present-day world thought? Can there be any re-orientation of Gandhian Ideology to make the lot of present man richer, noble and happier—all such new attempts are indicated without any blind bias whatsoever.*

The ever-increasing influence of Gandhian Ideology is immensely felt all over the world by each and every nation irrespective of their national inclinations, traditional inherits and democracies. This is however indicative of its creative synthesis, greater harmonisation and world unification based on its universal appeal. Gandhian trend has arborised every domain of contemporary thought not due to its characteristic a-typical nature but mainly because of its force of thought, extent of universal application and creative synthetic character. This ideological synthesis of Gandhian thought contributed largely towards national and international integration precipitating and crystallising the national and international ideologies of co-existence and world-peace in modern times.

If we attempt to analyse the synthetic ideology of Gandhi in the context of the present-day world we find some incoherent inconsistencies despite of its most original and fundamental unity of thought. This divergency is not due to any incompatibility of Gandhian Ideology with the existing world-thought, but it is

mainly due to the distortion of real thought and its wrong application both on ideological and practical levels. Hardly there are few among the educated intelligentsia who can claim to have rightly imbibed the synthetic ideology of Gandhi. It is however not wrong to say that every commoner of the Commonwealth of Nations in the contemporary period is able to feel about the greatness of Gandhi and his inviolable impact on the world of today and tomorrow. Knowing rightly about Gandhi by the negligible few is different from feeling truly for him by many. This is indeed the most significant paradox of the period in which we live and tend to formulate some principles of thought and action. However, the universality of Gandhian thought has superseded over its clarity in modern times.

Gandhi was deeply influenced by the humanist idealism of India's past. He believed in the deeper potentialities of man and his intrinsic goodness. Gandhi had a firm faith in oneness of humanity. "I believe in absolute oneness of humanity as much as I believe in the absolute oneness of God." The synthetic ideology of Gandhi apart from its integral quality of absoluteness has very well depicted its unique quality of unity of man as "I believe in the essential unity of man and for that matter of all that lives "

There is a reciprocal relationship between the present-day world ideology and Gandhian ideology. Gandhian thought rendered values to the world-thought while the world ideology with its scientific currents and cross-currents of thought has conditioned Gandhian ideals and thus facilitated in its wider application. The applicability of the basic teachings of Gandhi in one way resulted in the universality of his ideology. Thus, the altruistic, positivistic and humanistic philosophies that tend to dominate the contemporary world are however never isolated from the Gandhian trends which reticulate every fibre of modern thought.

Gandhism, even in the heights of its high Idealism is never isolated from the influences of radicalism that readily dominates the twentieth century contemporary thought. For example when

we analyse the most popular sayings of Gandhi like 'rights follow the duties', 'the ends are in means', 'utilise the present and ensure the future' and other sayings regarding the greatest good of all the dignity of labour etc., we discover some realistic and rationalistic trends of thought which very well indicate positivistic signs of human evolution and progress. Such peculiarities which are embedded in his ideology not only made Gandhi a pioneer of modern thought but they ultimately made him the great prophet of his age.

If we critically examine Gandhi's labour theory of work and Marx's labour theory of value in relation to capital we find a striking contrast between the two powerful ideologies. Marx incited labour against Capital to subvert capitalism while Gandhi created marriage between Capital and labour to sublimate over-exploitation. Marx in his system encouraged the overthrow of capitalism by force and gave birth to class-war leading to dialectics in his economic thought while Gandhi in his system encouraged the wilful co-operation between capital and labour through love and thus gave birth to radical and humanistic concepts of "*Aparigraha*" or abstinence from all forms of capital in his social philosophy which is however not accepted by a section of free-thinkers of the modern period.

Can we say emphatically that our national ideology is but the real *pratibimba* or reflection of Gandhian Ideology? If, it is not so, is there any divergence in modern times? Can there be any re-orientation of Gandhian ideology to make the lot of present man richer, nobler and happier? These are some of the very few salient problems that pose the creative mind of modern man.

If we evaluate some of the past and the present ideologies which claim universality of their thought and compare the same with that of the Gandhian ideology we find more resemblances than divergencies. For example the high idealism of Plotinus, the religious philosopher of Greece and Sri Aurobindo, the mystic saint of India and Gandhi, all very nearly resemble the same. Again the ideals of naturalism as preached by Augustus Comte, Thomas

Huxley and Gandhi are basically one and the same. The principles of social pedagogy as envisaged by Karl Groose and Malbranche are never different from the Gandhian ideals of "*Nai Talim*." Further, in his sublime spiritualistic doctrines he is nearer to Saint Luke, Saint Anselm, St. Augustine, and St. Thomas Aquinas. Further again, the radicalism of John Locke and Ruskin is very well reflected in Gandhian social thought. The social and liberal thought of Gandhi is akin to the social and liberal thought of Rousseau and his illustrious disciple Pestalozzi. In his high ideals of elevated social realism Gandhi is in line with Leo Tolstoy on one hand and Boris Pasternak on the other and lastly in his primary principles of religious ideology he tends to approximate with the emanistic ideals of Albert Schweitzer and Rudolf Otto alike.

The scientific teachings of Gandhian ideals in the context of the ever-evolving ideals of technology, its wider applicability in terms of its quality of thought are however needed to be well accepted by the comity of the world nations of today. The study of Gandhi independent of India's independence and rational recognition of Gandhi as a citizen of the world much above as an Indian national will indeed pave a way for a higher ideological unification in modern times. The racial and national barriers have served as inviolable checks in each and every period of past history. Likewise every nation attempted to hold high their own national heroes irrespective of their innumerable scrabbles as necessary pre-requisites in shaping their national ideologies from age to age. Gandhi is however no exception to this, but greatness of Gandhi is unsurmountable as much as his goodness is unsurpassable.

For Gandhi GOD is one by whatever name you prefer to call Him. You call Him *Rama* or *Rahim*, or *Allah*, *Christ* or *Budha*, but the essential unity is unchangeable. Gandhi's belief requires a living faith in a living God who is the ultimate arbiter of our fate. Without Him not a blade of grass moves. For Gandhi God is the ultimate reality behind the Universe which is always in a

state of universal flux. God alone is real, the world is an illusion. He alone persists in the midst of change. I dimly perceive that informing power of God. *In the midst of death life persists, in the midst of untruth, truth persists, in the midst of darkness, light persists, in the midst of hatred, love persists and lastly in the midst of vice, virtue persists. Hence I gather that God is life, truth, light, love and virtue which is good.* Gandhi does not need a logical proof for the existence of God. He says that the real testimony of God lies not in the extraneous evidence but in the transformed conduct and character which is based on some intrinsic experience of God. Such a testimony is to be found in the experiences of an unbroken line of prophets and sages in all countries and climes. To reject such a pious evidence is to deny one's primal existence. In *Plato's hierarchy* of ideas we find that supreme good is placed at the apex of his theory which is however, later on considered as identical with Divine God. In Plato we find further that the science of ideas aimed at the absolute truth of things, which however arose out of a union of the Socratic concept and the Heraclitean notion of flux. This idea is the unifying principle of all the ideas and the cornerstone of Plato's entire philosophy. In the words of Plato "The Good is nothing else than God himself." In Gandhi we find both the opposing currents synthesised into one stream, the stream of reality principle of the supreme good which is God Himself.; Which however, is the antithesis of the two ideas of changeable and unchangeable elements of God. Thus the nuclear element of Gandhi's thought was his idea of God, while all other elements ranged round this centre in a peculiar way to form a peculiar pattern. Though, Gandhi was opposed to fatalism, on one hand, he was a firm believer in the theory that man can shape his destiny by his own action and on the other hand, he believed like Aurobindo that man's perfection and liberation can come only by self-surrender and divine grace. In his autobiography he says that :

"For perfection or freedom from error comes only from grace and without an unreserved surrender to this grace complete mastery over thought is impossible."



This is indeed typical of a Theist like Gandhi. On the other hand Shankara and his orthodox followers the Advaitins or Monistic Vedantins do not believe in grace but in knowledge as the path to liberation. Our studies of "Young India" embark upon us the fundamental conceptions of God in which Gandhi declares that "To me God is Truth and Love, God is Ethics and Morality." In the same breath he continues and says that "God is Conscience. He is even atheism of the atheist. He is also a greatest tyrant ever known, for he often dashes the cup from our lips as to provide mirth for Himself at our expense." Therefore, in a universal flux it is that Hinduism calls this sport 'Lila' or calls it an illusion or 'Maya.' Here Gandhi tends to harmonise with the idea of ecstatic dance of Shiva of Sri Aurobindo. Students of philosophy may find in this description a very similar parallel to the famous description of God by the greatest scientific mathematician-Philosopher of the century. Alfred North Whitehead in his 'Process and Reality' says "It is as true to say that God is permanent and the world fluent, as that the world is permanent and God fluent. It is as true to say that God is one and the world many, as that the world is one and God many." The similarity between the two lies in their attempts to comprehend in one synthetic sweep that divergent aspects of God-head by thus imposing too great a strain on the customary moulds of thought. Thus God for him was the all-pervasive reality, immanent in man and also in the world, which he regarded as His manifestation and creation. But unlike an ordinary Pantheist he believed that God was also transcendent. Gandhi has thus a comprehensive conception of God like that of the Western Pantheists. He is not only a pantheist but a Panentheist in the words of Max Muller. Gandhi like Sankara tries to reconcile the immanence with the transcendence of God in his later writings 'on the theory of God'. Benedict Spinoza considered God as a substance, Acharya Sankara considered God as Nirguna and Mahatma Gandhi considered God as Nirakara in the absolute sense. For this reason Spinozism of Spinoza, the Advaitism of Sankara and the Super-theism of Gandhi all attribute to some or other forms of

monistic philosophies. In our previous delineations we have dealt in detail with the eminent aphorisms of Gandhi as "God exists" "God alone exists." "God is everything," "God is truth, Love, knowledge and Bliss." These aphorisms of Gandhi may unconsciously lead him to '*Anekavada*' or '*Syadvada*' which is however characteristic of his philosophy. "People may brand me as Syadvadi or Pluralist, but my Syadvada is not the Syadvada of the learned, it is peculiarly my own." Some Western critics are of the opinion that Gandhi was more at home in his diversity rather than unity as much as Leibnitz who delighted in his heirarchy of monads and Herbert who took pride in his "many things-in-themselves." In this way Gandhi's God is the combination of God as Love of Bergson, God in man of Aurobindo, and finally God or Man of Hertman. Gandhi never gave any proofs for the existence of God, except few statements as "*If we exist, if our parents have existed then it is proper to believe in the Parent of the whole creation.*" This clearly shows as how Gandhi unconsciously blended the cosmological and teleological arguments in favour of the existence of God. Inspite of such arguments Gandhi like Lotze is of the opinion that without the proper communion and direct experience with God, none can be convinced of the unseen power which invariably becomes a glaring reality and thus tends to transform the devotee into an active potential of the great mission of God. Gandhi also agrees with Samuel Alexander, the British Philosopher who exclaimed that "It is our mental responses to objects that discover the objects to us" However with these mental responses of faith that Gandhi came to strengthen his belief in God. In the very first Sutra Umaswami states this cardinal teaching as *Samyag-Darsana* or the right faith as the attitude of respect or *Siaddha* towards truth. In Jaina philosophy this is considered as one of the three Jems or *Tri-ratna* that shine in a good life. Hence in the light of our present discussion we can class Gandhi under omniscient Trithankaras who have already attained liberation on this planet - the Earth.

The critical consideration of Gandhi's views on religion marks some original and fundamental conceptions. For Gandhi religion

is not subscription to dogmas or conformity to rituals but an abiding faith in the absolute values of Truth, Love and Justice and a persistent endeavour to realise them on earth. Gandhi firmly believes that the neglect of religious education would undermine the moral fibre of society. "Life without religion I hold, is life without principle", Says Gandhi on one occasion. The religion as envisaged by Gandhi is thus free from the superstition of rigid custom and religious dogmas. There is no religion according to him higher than Truth and Righteousness. For him true religion and true morality are inseparably bound up with each other. To put this into his own words 'Religion is to morality what water is to the seed that is sown in the soil.' According to Gandhi different religions are like different roads converging to the same point. "Even as a tree has a single trunk, but many branches and leaves, so there is one true and perfect religion, but it becomes many as it passes through the human medium." Gandhi thus affirms that there is a rock-bottom unity between all religions, which is at once universal and absolute truth and which is beyond all creeds and faiths. Unless there is a state religion Gandhi affirms it is very difficult if not impossible to provide religious instruction as India can never be a theocratic state imposing the State religion on all its subjects. Gandhi believes in imparting religious education on private but on conscious levels. In this connection Gandhi emphasising upon Prayer, asserts, that prayer is the very soul and essence of religion, for Prayer in his view is not asking but it is a longing of the soul. Renunciation for Gandhi was not flying away from the world nor salvation a post-mortem goal. That religion which takes no account of practical affairs and does not help to solve them is no religion. If a particular man has reached to the heart of his own religion, he has reached the hearts of the others too. The Religion of Gandhi never justifies animal sacrifices. If such sacrifices have been a feature with vedic Society it can form no precedent for a votary of *Ahimsa*. Gandhi justifying caste-system in its historical context says that 'caste may be regarded as man's experiment or social adjustment in the laboratory of Indian Society.' Gandhi justifying Idol worship in its social context says that 'I do not disbelieve in idol worship, I

think, Idol worship as the part of human nature. We hanker after symbolism'. If we study Gandhi's religious attitude we find in it a triangular truth as it is revealed clearly in his personal writings.' 'All religions are equally true, All religions have equally dear to me'. The word religious tolerance implies a gratuitous assumption according to Gandhi. He therefore prefers the word religious reverence "It is easy enough to be friendly to one's friends, but to befriend the one who regards himself as your enemy is the quintessence of true religion". Gandhi never gave any extra sanctions to any religion as an exception. Writing in the *Har'jan*, he says that 'I cannot ascribe exclusive divinity to Jesus. He is as divine as Krishna or Rama or Muhammad or Zoaaster.' If we aim at studying the evolution of the philosophy of religion in the present context of religious tolleration we find in Locke a true emblem of religious unity. On one hand Locke in his treatise on "Toleration" advocates toleration on the ground that 'it is irrational to compel men to believe' and on the other hand he seeks to encourage unity among the diverse sects of religion by emphasising the common points of popular religions. Kant's teleological ideas lead naturally to his views on religion. Religion according to Kant can only come after morality. According to Hegel the dualism which art reveals between the finite and the infinite can only be reconciled in religion in which the worshiper and the object of worship come together eliminating the medium of symbolic forms. Gandhi's emphasis on the moral basis of religion is indicative of his original approach to the subject. Instead of reproducing old and out-worn theories of religion he boldly asserts that we cannot conceive of religion apart from morality. For him religion divorced from morality is like 'Sounding brass, good only for making a noise and breaking heads'.

Gandhi's life has become immortal not because he got Swaraj for India not because he was the apostle, of Truth and Non-violence but he is considered in the eyes of the World as the inventor of some new values, as an originator of a new philosophy of life. 'Not round the inventor of new noises, but round the

inventor of new values doth the world revolve'. In the first trinity of divine principles of Plotinus we find The *Absolute* or the primal essence, the *Nous* or the pure intelligence and the *psyche* or the world soul. In Sri Aurobindo's upper principles we find *Satchidanand* i. e. pure being, the conscious force, and the Bliss. This is the triune principle of supermind. The first principle of Gandhi comprises of Truth, Goodness and Love. Thus the Plotinian triad, the upper principle of Sri Aurobindo and the Gandhian trinity basically go together as sublime and eternal principles governing the world and the Universe. The consensus of contemporary thought has placed Gandhi among the greatest men of all times not because he was the author of some novel moral ideals, but because he is the inventor of new values based upon new scheme of events. In our summing up we can say that Gandhi did not only fight for the freedom of India but also strived to lay the foundations of a new world order. Socratic maxims indicate that "knowledge is virtue" and Gandhi proved that "Virtue is Knowledge", and thus glorified the inversion of values. Both Marx and Prince Kropotkin advocated *Education integrale* or complete education in which the pernicious distinction between CULTURE and labour was conspicuous by its absence. Gandhi envisaged the idea of a co-operative community; for this reason he was later on rightly considered as the spearhead of Social Revolution, in the contemporary world. As Rousseau was the prophet of creative education in the West Gandhi was the prophet of creative education in the East. As Rousseau had an illustrious disciple in Pestalozzi so Gandhi had an illustrious disciple in Jawaharlal, selflessly strived for the wholesome materialisation and glorification of the intrinsic values of their respective masters and dominated their age in which they lived and strived. Thus we have attempted to elucidate and clarify the basic assumption of Gandhian outlook on life. It is clear from the outset that Gandhi's thought cannot be considered a philosophical system in any scholastic form but rather a system of active thought where thought and action are so interlinked that every step in thought manifests itself in some form of action. Gandhi then a teacher who has shown us the way to a life of righteousness not only on the individual plane, but also on every level of social and political planning. Hence our appreciation of Gandhi's thought depends much on our realisation of the basic aims and objectives of his philosophy. ●

## VINOBA

*Acharya Vinoba Bhave, the Walking Saint of India with his creative ideals of ever-growing Sarvodaya Samaj is fast tending to dominate the contemporary thought both social and moral.*

*Sarvodaya Ideology is considered as a creative blend of all humanistic and altruistic tendencies of the age. It can however be interpreted in terms of an Integrated Social Philosophy in this age of Crisis.*

Sarvodaya is not a passive resistance to evil as much as positive assimilation of Good. The Sarvodaya Ideology is a creative synthesis of individual happiness and social good. It is indeed considered as the integrated social philosophy which redeems the reform of the individual as the reform of the society.

The Utilitarians led by Jeremy Bentham pleaded for "the greatest good of the greatest numbers" in the past. The Sarvodaya seekers inspired by Acharya Vinoba Bhave tend to implore the good of all, the allay of all and ultimately the welfare of all.

This insistence on individual purity which is an experience *Suigeneris* of an ideal Sarvodayi implies an immanent reform of the individual. Again, the existence of social appetite in Sarvodaya Ideology is indicative of a new social evolution in modern times. Thus, this contemporaneous process of individual reform and social good tend to evolve a new humanist philosophy hitherto unknown to human history.

Albert Schweitzer, the great altruist of the modern period advocated "will-to-love" one and all in his philosophy of Universal benevolence. Acharya Vinoba Bhave, the Walking Saint of India preached "will-to-do good" to all through his humanitarian ideals of Sarvodaya Philosophy. Acharya Bhave, like Albert Schweitzer very well believes in Life and World-affirmation. The egalitarian outlook of Acharya Vinoba Bhave and his deep faith in the oneness of Man and the ideal of human unity, draws him nearer to Albert Schweitzer's cardinal belief in "Reverence for Life". As Albert Schweitzer is considered by many as the moving and guiding spiritual force of the West, so Acharya Bhave is a living and inspiring symbol of the thirst-quenching wisdom of the East.

Sarvodaya Ideology is a dynamic energising force, it is moral motivation within the individual and a social movement without the individual. The re-making of man by renovating his creative energies and re-creating his environment by re-shaping its rich resources form the dynamic ideals of Sarvodaya Samaj. However, a communitarian society striving for humanist civilization was the ideal with almost all the creative Prophets of the past. Acharya Vinoba Bhave is no exception to this. An ever-envolving individual being aspiring for an ever-growing social consciousness forms one of the most leading themes of Sarvodaya trend of thought.

Acharya Vinoba Bhave has decided to make his life fit his thoughts as Albert Schweitzer. While Albert Schweitzer is considered as the creative prophet of Altruism in the West, Acharya Vinoba Bhave can rightly be called as a creative Prophet of Humanism in the East. Modern civilization is ailing with all forms of physical, moral and spiritual injuries. Quite recently the psychical injuries crept-in causing a great menace to the self-regarding ideals of man. Against such horrible background, the two great living Prophets of the world both Albert Schweitzer and Acharya Vinoba Bhave advocated the self-cultivation of certain human values which give man the desired courage and confidence to meet the ever-arising artificial challenges of society. The establishment of favourable conditions to one and all with the

sole view of perfecting the individuals form the basis of ethical thought with the two eminent thinkers of the present age. Both the prophets affirm that internal progress of humanity invariably leads to its external progress. The essential spiritual advance of mankind is the real and ideal progress. Both Acharya Vinoba Bhave and Albert Schweitzer carry universal world-views with them. Again perpetual peace is an ideal with both. The existence of order in the universe is very well preached by Schweitzer as Bhave—the author of the ideal of moral universe in the recent past.

Count Leo Tolstoy, who abandoned his normal career, impelled by his intense sincerity of thought wrote “What then must we do” a deep study of economic conditions in which he clearly represented the growing need for socio-economic equalities through peaceful revolution. Acharya Vinoba Bhave who initially preferred to lead a life of an ascetic inspired by Gandhian principles of living, set-out on a walking expedition of rural India. Throughout his travel Acharya Vinoba Bhave kept the idea of economic equality of the masses in the background of his mind. However, the ever-growing dynamic interaction between his super-sensitive mind and the collective mind of the ever-aspiring masses rendered him with an irresistible confidence from occasion to occasion throughout his noble mission of Bhoodan. This aspect of his life can be viewed to a great extent along with the idealised picture of Moses as related through the Talmudic legends who happens to have led most heroically and successfully his followers to the destined goal of liberation. Acharya Vinoba Bhave is an ascetic by nature but his asceticism never kept him in mere isolation. On the other hand he moved courageously into the masses and could very well find a place in their hearts for generations to follow. As Tolstoy, he is gifted with an amazing spiritual power which however inspired every walk of his life. The writings, conversations and exhortations of Bhave are living testimonies to this power. The union of great moral and spiritual power and immense imaginative vision with a high sense of purpose coupled with some realistic details about Socio-economic



set-up at once make him one of the great popular Prophets of the Age. Acharya Vinoba Bhave like the Russian Reformer of the recent past is striving his best to implant "the kingdom of Heaven" upon earth.

John Ruskin the humanitarian writer who lived in the early part of the 19th century turned to Economics of his age and wrote innumerable thought provoking articles to the leading journals. However, his treatises and articles were later on republished as 'Unto this Last.' All his writings aimed at economic emancipation, social reform and national education of the masses. He wrote epigrammatic language and read Bible throughout his life. On the other hand Acharya Vinoba Bhave the living humanist of the present age with his egalitarian ideals of economic equality, social enlightenment and communitarian polity, is fast tending to bring about social transformation through peaceful revolution. Every word of Acharya is accepted by the people as a valuable treasury of human good as he himself is the living embodiment of good. John Ruskin pleaded for the laws of Social affection as necessary pre-requisites to the laws of Political Economy in the past; On the other hand Acharya Bhave preached the laws of Social affection to accompany the self-governing laws of local community reform. This is indeed considered as a spiritual movement towards socio-economic emancipation of the masses. The self-regulating and self-governing ideals as the primary requisites of the participating democracy indeed gave a new turn to the agro-industrial economy of the nation in these days. John Ruskin is well-known as a critic of political economy while Acharya Bhave is widely known as the Architect of the down-trodden and under-developed.

Schleiermacher who lived in the early part of the 18th century preached Ideal-realism which is the creative blend of the real as well as the ideal tendencies of life. The feeling of dependence of man on the superior Power is the essence of religious Prophet of Ideal-realism. On other hand the feeling of dependence of man on the superior power of Justice and good sense of

man form the subject-matter of Sarvodaya Ideology. The religion, according to Vinoba Bhave is not seated in the emotional nature of man. Religion never excludes the elements of reason and volition. The mental field of man in admitting the principles of religious consciousness cannot by any reason reject the innate and the most essential attributes of his being i. e., the self-conscious Samskaras.

Acharya Vinoba Bhave the walking saint of India can be compared with innumerable spiritual sages and saints who dominated the world-thought through their selfless substantial action. To this category we can add St. Albans, St. Bernard St. Gregory, and St. Albertus Magnus etc. However, the magical influence of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi upon his trusted and the most devoted disciple Acharya Vinoba Bhave cannot be overlooked. The impact of Gandhi on Vinoba is so immense that we cannot categorically say that the latter is much influenced by the former except saying that Vinoba is but the living, moving and inspiring shadow of Mahatma Gandhi. What Gandhiji has visualised to practice in his life itself apart from what he has been practising throughout is left to Vinoba to practise in his Present life.

The religious aspect of Sarvodaya circumscribes around the central reality *Tattvam asi* i. e., 'That art thou'. Bhakti based on Manusmriti is the ideal content of Sarvodaya religion. Bhakti is not a mental state. It is an emotional attachment and an ecstatic expression of self. Self-will and Activity is the essential element of Sarvodaya religious consciousness. For, Vinoba, religion is not a sightless subscription to traditional dogmas or heedless conformity to Pristine and ancient Rituals. It is above-all on abiding and a living faith, in the three cardinal values of Truth, Love and Justice. As Gandhian religion was one persistent endeavour to attain a higher life in this world itself, so the living trend of Sarvodaya religion tends to materialise a higher life of Angelic righteousness in this world of increasing insecurity. *Samnyāsa* is neither total renunciation of the world nor it is total cessation of all activity. Renunciation in Sarvodaya means the absence of hankering after fruit of action and not indifference to its results. (*Karma-Phala-Tyaga*).

Innumerable philosophers of the past interpreted religion in a variety of ways. Religion according to Hegel is a form of representative knowledge. Kantian religion is a fulfilment of morality; Otto expressed that religion is an experience *Sui-generis*. According to Fries religion is divination which is 'AHUNDUNG'. Leuba calls it as an absorption in the divine Substance. Religion in James opinion is based on mystical consciousness and so it is only pursued in solitude. Frank asserted on ethico-religious consciousness and Caird pleaded for the elevation of human spirit into union with the Divine through his religious ideal. Stoical view of religion is in the nature of Pantheism. From God all beings proceed and to Him all return at last. The incarnation of God in men forms the core of all Christian religious consciousness.

In the recent years Arnold J. Toynbe In his 'Historians' approach to Religion' very well signified the course of higher religions. Higher religions have uniform and universal codes and beliefs which tend to unite mankind on all levels of existence. Albert Schweitzer the great altruist of the present age advocated the ideal of reverence for life through his religion. 'Religion is to morality what water is to the seed that is sown in the soil', said Mahatma Gandhi. Marxian religion is the opiate of the masses.

The rich wealth of variety of religious consciousness is embodied in Bhagwadgita, the *Sad-Darsanas* and in Advaita Vedanta of Shankara. Religion is something which must be experienced and not defined in India. It is the intuitive love of God. The basic teachings of other major faiths by which men live – Confucianism, Taoism, Islam and Judaism etc., also indicated high religious beliefs based on intuitive love of God and His greatness. Indian idealism advocates a new religious revival through Sarvodaya. This new religious revival can alone save the world from utter annihilation and wholesome destruction. Sarvodaya teaches a dynamic religion based both on human morality and as well as social morality. Sarvodaya pleads for a unifying force among the present religions of the world nations. Sarvodaya is against any form of state-imposed religious consciousness. Sarvodaya prayer is a longing of the soul, a medium of self-purification. Sarvodaya takes interest in the self of all mankind through its inviolable spirit of self-surrender based on self-realisation.

Sarvodaya religious consciousness tends to satisfy all the needs of a Natural religion. That there is one God, that He ought to be worshiped, that worship consists of piety and sympathy, that we must reform our actions and that we should surrender our means and ends to the welfare of all characterise main attributes of Sarvodaya religious consciousness.

St Francis was one of the greatest lovers of God and also one of the greatest lovers of men. He was an ardent desciple of Jesus. He travelled extensively to redress the grievances of the people and thus alleviate their suffering. Similarly Acharya Vinoba Bhave is both a lover of God and a lover of men. Again as a true desciple of Gandhi he travelled extensively to meet the ailing humanity in accordance with the duty expected of him i. e., *Kartavya-Karma*. Vinoba exists in-and-through society. He lays his individual being in this world as well as in the other world. He has an existential communion with other men as much as his inspirational contact with the Spirit. Vinoba is tending to preach the ideal of Universal benevolence to the human race in general. His philosophy can be categorised under Social Altruism in modern times. '*Jai-Jagat*' or the welfare of the whole world has become the Manual of Ethics of Acharya in these days. Quite recently he gave a generic slogan '*Jai-Jagao*' to the people. *Jnana-Karma-Samvacaya* is the summumbonum of his integral philosophy. He is purifying knowledge with action and reforming action with knowledge in more than one way. Acharya Vinoba Bhave as an agrarian reformer of the first rank has successfully introduced an element of voluntarism in capitalism, through his creative ideals of Bhoodan. Thus Sarvodaya is felt as a perennial philosophy and Acharya is viewed as an Alchemist of world character in modern times. Acharya, again is no less than a sage who by his implicit faith and selfless action became one with his mission. An unvolunerable Knight fighting with magic armour was said of Gandhi by Dean Inge in the past. Acharya Bhave has got into the place of Gandhi in this respect. Acharya Bhave like cardinal Newman is a great missionary by nature and again like Marcus Aurelius he is imbued with a dynamic ideal of world unity. His followers are spread like the noble knights of King Arthur

throughout the nation, nay even throughout the world working sincerely for the cause of humanity.

Sarvodaya is a well-integrated social and moral philosophy. It is however considered as a recent tendency particularly in social philosophy. Sarvodaya is a new movement towards life. It is a synthetic ideology and a universal concept. It is indeed an improvement over all forms of creative altruism, and evolutionary humanism. Its communitarian outlook draws it nearer to Social Universalism. The essential doctrines of Sarvodaya are however superior to the doctrines of some of the significant social theories both old and new. The social theories preached by Totalitarian communism, Democratic socialism and Parliamentary democracy seemed to have failed in bringing about the desired Social Integration. Sarvodaya, on the other hand as an evolutionary social concept seems to have succeeded to a certain extent in establishing a social cohesion at least on ideological levels of human consciousness in modern times. *Lokayatika* doctrines of Carvaka attempted to achieve lower carnal integration in the past. The Mahayana teachings of Buddhism aimed at a greater and higher unification of mankind through its most generic ideal of *Bodhisattva* in the 6th century B. C. Ashoka the spirited ruler of India in the succeeding ages has attempted to unite the world through his noble attitude towards life. Conversion and not coercion, revolution and not revocation was the main motto of his moral ambition. In modern times Gandhi and Vinoba have turned the course of human history towards new vistas of human evolution. Many a Prophet and a preacher of the past have invariably attempted to establish general human integrations in their own periods. For example, Marx aimed at material integration of mankind; Rousseau opted for social integration of mankind; Ashoka endeavoured for moral integration and quite recently Sri Aurobindo inspiringly designed for a spiritual integration of mankind. On the other hand Acharya Vinoba Bhave in the contemporary period seems to have over-whelmingly engaged in bringing about the 'total human integration' from all angles and aspects of the present race of mankind. Nonetheless, he is the true embodiment of human race itself; an embodiment which embraces the total and integral well-being of man in modern times ADIEU. ●

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### **Other Publications of Author**

1. Universalism
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